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Tony Marino

Tony Marino has been the bassist of choice for a number of significant jazz artists, including Joe Lovano, Dave Liebman and Phil Woods. He honed his skills as a house bassist in venues throughout the Poconos and Catskills.

Tony was interviewed via Zoom on August 25, 2025 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe for the Fillius Jazz Archive and I'm very pleased to have bassist Tony Marino with me today. Welcome, sir.

TM: Thank you. Hello.

MR: It's a pleasure to have you. I'd like to start out with a quote I read that I'm going to use a blank for the name. It was from Dave Liebman. Dave Liebman said, "I may have said three words to blank about how or what to play. He's the most distinctive musician I have known." Who do you think Dave was talking about?

TM: Well just, I guess my ability off-the-cuff and to respond basically. You know nothing stellar but definitely I have my moments. You know?

MR: Musicians, jazz players especially, talk about being in the moment. When you say respond to things, can you describe how that works to people who don't really understand it?

TM: Well we all know a language, a basic language. We've all grown up playing song forms, we've, you know, touched base on playing with no song form. Now song form what I mean is a definite set of rules that we play with. And we all know a lot of the same song forms. So you could be in the country like Japan and not be able to speak a word to a guy but you start playing "Autumn Leaves" and everybody knows what to do immediately. And we go off of, for instance if I think of "Autumn Leaves" I think of Miles Davis immediately. Then I think of his introduction with the G minor 6th cord, and that whole Latin thing. Or no – you know what I'm thinking, now I'm thinking of the other tune – "Blackbird." But anyway "Autumn Leaves" I definitely think of those bands. So our ears all go to that area, you know, stuff that we've listened to and we can all relate by that. So on the bandstand we're definitely choosing and picking stuff that – to get us started. So licks if you will, or riffs, you know we'll use stuff like that when we're improvising. The melody is another thing you know. And we'll use the melody in improvisation too, besides the chords. But we're listening very hard to each other. So we were trying to get somewhere that we haven't gone before, you know a space ride if you will. So we're listening hard and someone could make a statement, and it could be visual, it could be audible, whatever it is on the bandstand, and react to it. Or he'll leave space. That's

another great thing that we have on the bandstand is space. And how to use space. So a great horn player will leave space for the rhythm section to do something with it. So that's our opportunity. Now there's three other rhythm section members normally that are participating you know. So you've got to be sensitive as to when to jump and do your thing you know. But you could be a leader of, you know, this movement, or you can stand back and go for the ride you know.

MR: Has the role of the main timekeeper changed over the decades? And I guess I should precede that with who do you think is the main timekeeper in the band?

TM: That's a good question. That's been thrown around a lot. You know in a lot of ways I could say it's me, the bass player. But I mean the drummer is basically – he's the orchestrator you know. He's creating the colors. But when I'm playing I'm listening hard to where he's putting the time. So I want to match with him. I want to groove. You know. A lot of our music is groove. There's other aspects of our music that's not groove, that's rubato and up-in-the-air and ethereal and whatever other adjective I can come up with. But for sure I'm listening hard to the drummer and matching where we are so we create a groove. And we could go anywhere. We could change the groove you know, we could double it up, we could go slower, I mean there's all kinds of excitement, and part of that Dave Liebman group, since you brought his name up, he really encouraged that kind of movement. And for a keyboard player or guitar player he really, he wanted a lot of times, harmony thrown at him. He didn't want the norm, ever. And I think that comes with him playing with Miles Davis, you know? And our band I think was pretty closely associated with Miles Davis' band. You know. I'm speaking of the later band with, you know, Herbie and Ron and Tony and Wayne.

MR: This will be totally speculative, but you've played with some marvelous saxophone players over the years and I'm thinking in my mind comparing like Zoot Sims with Dave Liebman. Zoot Sims probably came early in your career.

TM: Yeah. Well I used to – being here in Pennsylvania, Phil Woods' band was in town you know, and Phil lived in Delaware Water Gap. And his rhythm section guys lived in the Poconos. So I was associated with them. And it's word of mouth musicians you know. And also in our area I'll say, Al Cohn – Al Cohn I was at a restaurant playing somewhere and he liked me. So that was the first gig I ever played in New York City was with him at Fat Tuesday's, a club called Fat Tuesday's, and we played downstairs. And so that meeting, and this bass player, Phil Woods' bass player, Steve Gilmore, would recommend me for things you know. And I got to play with Zoot with Al. It was one of Zoot's last gigs actually, at the Blue Note and I was thrilled to be part of it and we sat in the, I remember sitting in the what do you call it, the green room upstairs at the Blue Note and him complaining about young musicians not knowing tunes, not wanting to know

tunes, not learning enough tunes. So that was basically part of our discussion while he hit a little vodka on the side there.

MR: Why would a young musician not find knowing tunes worthwhile?

TM: Well that's a good question. I did learn them. I mean I did gigs where you had to. It was dance – a lot of times dance music and you'd have to play medleys of tunes. You know Frank Sinatra songbook you know. And I learned to fake as well. So I got away with murder in a lot of ways you know, because I faked. But I mean all the older musicians as I'd say, they all knew those tunes. I mean you had to know those tunes. And I think the younger guys, it's what they're listening to. You know they're listening to Trane, maybe later Trane. Or Miles, the later groups you know. Or the fusion bands of the '70s. You know I miss the '60s. I was a kid you know, so '70s was where I was really starting to play professionally and you know my like for like say fusion music, which I enjoyed, which took me from rock music. I wanted to know how those guys learned what they learned. And so then I heard about Charlie Parker. I heard about Miles Davis. So I went backwards in time, you know, to find out where – you know after the virtuosity you know? A guy that can really kill his instrument. And one of the guys for me of course was New York State's Scott LaFaro you know. Of course we all – I mean he ruined a lot of bass players I guess for band leaders.

MR: Okay you have to explain that.

TM: Well okay, Scott LaFaro was a heavy member of Bill Evans' trio. Piano trio. And Bill had a new concept which was the bass part doesn't hold the time-keeping role, which you mentioned before. He's more of a counterpoint player you know. And more of a soloist. And Scott was a genius you know. Also a heavy practitioner. He practiced a lot. So he was able to do horn-like riffs on the bass and we marveled at his virtuosity. You know. And stories I've heard, I wasn't there you know, I never got to see him play live, but stories I heard was when Bill Evans' trio played live there was a long line of bass players going in to hear him play. And they were all crazy. So when they got on their gigs whether it was a dance gig or whatever, they tried to imitate him and the band leaders were going nuts because they weren't playing time. They weren't playing the dance music.

MR: The dancers were falling down.

TM: Yeah. You know they all wanted to solo and play in the upper register you know? So the bottom of the band would drop out. We couldn't wait for our moment you know.

MR: I think that kind of influence has even gone into the current day where, especially with electric bass players.

TM: Oh yeah.

MR: You know they have the facility to play like a saxophone player and so they're going to.

TM: I equate it more to guitar you know. 'Cause it's a whole different feel, horizontally playing. And these guys, I mean electric bass players and guitar players, you know, really get along. But you know, definitely horn players. Yeah.

MR: You started as a guitar player, right?

TM: I started playing as a guitar player because of my dad, yeah. I wanted to be a drummer but I lived in a second story apartment and that wasn't going to happen. As a matter of fact when I got a set of drums I put them in the basement and there was a gigantic fight so I had to get rid of them. And I tried rock bands in the cellar and everything and it didn't work out with my family so I had to get them out of there and find another place for them. But, so yeah I played a little guitar, I took some lessons, and in junior high I started with string bass 'cause of my sister's love for a Stan Getz record which had Astrud Gilberto on it, "The Girl from Ipanema." And she loved that record. And on the flip side of that record I remember was Stan's group swinging. And one of the songs the bassist starts off the tune playing the bass line for a blues, I think it was a blues. And I loved it. So when I got to junior high and I was able to get ahold of a string bass I went right for it. And of course I had known the guitar a little bit, it was easy for me to get in there except for the large intervals and big strings.

MR: How do you memorize tunes? Because I saw a video of you with Dave Liebman and you're playing "Lush Life" in the famous jazz club there in Delaware Water Gap.

TM: Oh Deer Head, yeah.

MR: You know this is not a question but it was an observation that the stage looked so small that Dave had to stand on the floor.

TM: Yeah. The rhythm section only fit on the bandstand, yeah.

MR: But I was thinking you know "Lush Life" is not an easy tune.

TM: No.

MR: You obviously had no music stand or iPad in front of you.

TM: No, a lot of times, no.

MR: So the general question is how do you do that? How do you memorize those things?

TM: Well you know off of the melody for sure. People will say a song title to me and I'll go, "Oh I'm not sure" and I'll say, "sing it." And once they start singing the melody I connect. Now that doesn't hook you up for the bridge necessarily you know. The old timers would tell me, "Learn the lyrics" which I never did. I wasn't good at learning lyrics. But if you learn the lyrics you would never forget the bridge. And they had great little tips to help younger guys out. But I never listened to lyrics. So I missed – I didn't like Bob Dylan for that reason. I hated his singing, and it took me years to get over that and to appreciate what he was about. And it was because of the bad singing. But you know the message that he was relaying you know and getting into that vibe. That's the

other thing that the old timers used to do, ballads, you know knowing the lyrics of the song, they really get inside of it you know and, you know, emotion would flow out of them you know.

MR: I liked it when I would watch a bandstand, and of course it would happen to me too. Sometimes the bass player would give the look to the piano player, or vice versa. You know the bridge is coming up and you give them the look.

TM: Yeah, yeah.

MR: You go, "Okay thanks for the look, what does it mean?"

TM: Yeah. Well the look means – it could mean what's the first chord, when is the bridge, do you know the bridge, I know the bridge. You know whoever the leader is in that moment, will give and take always on the bandstand. And that goes with when you're soloing and you're soloing on a tune you don't know well, you have a good accompanist, a great piano player or guitar player, they help. They can sense that I don't know this tune and maybe I blew a scale tone of a chord or I'm leading astray, I don't know the melody that well so my rhythmic phrasing is not together. And they'll help. They'll throw in and let you use your ear and find yourself you know. And I kind of consider myself more of an ear player than, you know, a musician by rote. Or – I used my ear a lot, all through the years that I've played. And playing those dance gigs that I did in the early stages really helped me with that. You know? Because I didn't know these tunes. I don't think they expected me to know all of them but I'd always get help from the piano player. He'd give me a bass note or just give me the first chord ahead of time, a little bit ahead of time. So we were always helping each other in the rhythm section.

MR: Were those dance gigs like at resorts, that kind of thing?

TM: Yeah.

MR: So did you early on did someone hip you to the two beat – you know play two beat and then later we'll go into four or that just kind of happened?

TM: Absolutely. Yeah. Oh there was rules. I mean you know when I did gigs in the Catskills I wasn't allowed to go – there a joke about this too, the Titanic (you probably know the joke you know). It's about the ship going down.

MR: Don't play in four or something like that.

TM: Like okay you can go into four now, when the water is up to your chin. But that was it. You stayed in two and when he gave me the four fingers, that was okay to swing. But yeah, it was all about dance music you know. And it got boring for a young musician. I wanted to – I wanted to do, I was listening to what everybody else I was listening to was doing as well you know. But when we played in the Poconos our little Garden of Eden was to run to the Deer Head Inn after the gigs. And there was a great piano player that played there every weekend, John Coates his name was.

MR: Oh yes. He's an author too as well I think.

TM: Oh yeah. He wrote a lot of music for Fred Waring who was across the street, the Pennsylvanian. They had a choral society and they wrote all kinds of arrangements for choral groups all over the world you know. So he was part of that. He wrote. But every weekend he was at the Deer Head. And he'd let us sit in. So here I'd get to play with John Coates and my friend Nelson Hill on saxophone, then I would run as fast as we could to get there and we would play, and then who knows like Phil Woods would show up, you know with his clarinet in his robe, you know to sit in with us and play. It was a great music lesson you know? All his years of experience and the strength of his sound and the conviction, the message he was saying, you know, just make you stand back, you know? You had to listen.

MR: That's such an interesting thing for you to say, and hard to explain to – like his intent, his message. You feel the need to really listen to what – and I don't know how you can explain how you could do that. Can you do it on purpose or is it just in him?

TM: Well I think both. I think both. If he sensed – well he was a guy, you know that school, that generation of players, if you didn't know your bridge or something he would humiliate you on the bandstand. You know? He would say nasty things in front of the audience to you, and you would shrink you know, but that's the way they were you know. They were tough that way. So you didn't want to play a tune you didn't know along with him. But yeah, his strength, just all the years and experience he played, you know he was so used to playing on certain chord progressions or not. You know he just knew what to do at the time. He was one of the greatest lead alto players of our time. And him and Quincy Jones especially, did a lot of stuff together. But you know he would be also the kind of guy that would, "Oh check these changes out on this bridge, you should check these changes out." You know? So he was always teaching as well you know. And I found out with a lot of the great players, they were always willing to give you help. And Dave Liebman was like that, this other saxophone player George Young, Al Cohn gave me opportunities you know. So I'm very lucky you know, to be able to play gigs and be on the bandstand with these gentlemen and move forward. Have that experience, you know?

MR: What were the – were there down years and up years or parts of decades that you could make a living – I won't say easier, I don't think it's ever easy –

TM: No.

MR: But less stress than others?

TM: Yeah I mean I think I kind of – where I fall into place there is like the tail end of a lot of the success in the music business where there were a lot of gigs you know. The gigs kind of died in New York City as well, a lot of the clubs, you know, the Philadelphia, you

know I used to play in Philly, I played New York, there were clubs, you know always places to play. Even in this area, Northeast Pennsylvania, there were always clubs with live music, and that's all changed. There's too much I think, too much media and people don't need to do it. And now you've got AI so I think the tough time is now. I don't know where it's going. I know a lot of songwriters are upset with the AI and I mean it's easy -- a band in a hologram now – so I mean you miss the human factor unfortunately. There are some glitches you know. I don't know much about AI but I know there's some glitches with it and to me I think there'll always be a small – at least in my hopes that there'll always be people out there that want to hear live musicians perform off the cuff you know, ad lib and go where it goes, whether it be free or song form or –

MR: So with that in mind if you're in a position where you get asked advice by a young hopeful bassist, do you have anything that you would say to them now perhaps that you wouldn't have had to say thirty years ago?

TM: Yeah it's not good news unfortunately. I tell them, you know if they're heading into college to definitely search out another degree to do something else than performance. Because performing live music is almost impossible today. You know if you get into a great school, you know one of the great schools, Eastman or Berklee or Texas – Denton, Texas – you know you'll meet – network people you know, and maybe that way you could you know hook up for some great gigs, some concerts and stuff like that. And it's lucky. You know? It's the luck of the draw more than ever now. And yeah I would say don't depend on making a living. I was lucky. I was able to do it and raise a family you know. But today, it's really –

MR: Well you're saying what Jerry Bergonzi said this thing almost off hand, he just said, "Well you have to have a job to support your gigs."

TM: Yeah. That's the truth. That's a nice light way of putting it you know. But it is, it's true. You know I never had to do that. And he was a great teacher so – and that's what most guys do now is teaching. You know so they're in the university teaching and I don't know, the young guys – there's some unbelievable young musicians. They have so much maturity at such a young age. And you know they blow my mind a lot of times at how much they know. And we're talking about tune knowledge. They know a ton of tunes as well. I think Zoot would have been happy, you know, that these young guys know so many tunes. But they know it all. I mean it's amazing. And well they have so much information now at their hands you know. We were putting the needle on the record basically and scratching up every record we owned to learn what we needed to learn.

MR: Did you have a short list of bass players that you said, "I want to sound like that"?

TM: Well I would put Scott LaFaro up there, I'd put Charlie Haden up there, I'd put Dave Holland. Oh there's so many. Paul Chambers I was really into, Ron Carter, oh there's a

lot. There's a lot of great young players. I love the Swedish bass player Anders Jormin – he's a newer guy now. Mike Formanek speaking of my peers. Steve Respina. Steve Gilmore was a big influence on me because he was part of Phil Woods' group, also Bill Goodwin. Bill Goodwin – I hooked up with him and we had a guitar trio with our late great friend Vic Juris that was the first record I did was through Bill. That was a really great hook-up for me.

MR: There's another video I saw, coincidentally close to me now at the Bop Shop.

TM: Yeah.

MR: And there's a video of you playing first of all I'm going to take a guess at the song. I don't know if you remember the incident but I think you were playing Stevie Wonder's "Overjoyed."

TM: Oh yeah. We played that, but I don't remember playing that at the Bop Shop.

MR: Well the reason I think you did is because you were, in your solo, playing little parts of the melody as if you were reminding everybody here's the song in case you forget.

TM: Yeah well I often do things like that because I can't play eighth notes. I try to but I'm not near as good as a horn player or a piano player. So I use melody a lot in my solos you know I definitely – or try to make up a new melody off of it you know. But you know when you listen to Phil Woods or Al Cohn and the real tune masters, they used the melody very much as well. They definitely – the phrasing from the melody alone was a big part of their thing you know. [Inaudible] phrasing.

MR: I can tell that that's been an influence on you because you would play a melodic lick and then you'd play it again, and if you did it a third time you would like alter it a bit. As if twice is good, three times you better do something to develop it. Or – but I did want to ask in this particular gig during your solo the piano player was just hitting a chord probably every four beats, very quietly. I heard nothing from the drummer. Now I'm not sure if there was a drummer but the question I'm finally going to ask is what do you like accompaniment-wise when it's time for the bass solo?

TM: Sometimes I like not to be accompanied at all and that gives me total freedom. And guys I play with a lot will give me the freedom to do that. You know? And it's up to me to make something happen. And sometimes I do and sometimes I need help and they'll sense it and they'll come back in, you know, on the bridge or something and, "Here we go, help Tony." But a lot of times I'll go by myself. You know I like of course to be able to hear myself, because a lot of times you play with people and they're playing over you and it's just hard to get your message across when they're doing that, and they're busy you know? So give me my space, that's all. And piano players and guitar players are such great accompanists usually. You know they work a lot with singers and horn players, that's what they do every day you know.

MR: I've heard other bass players say the opposite. Like don't you dare go to that hi-hat thing during the bass solo.

TM: Oh yeah, well some guys are really sticklers on what they want to hear you know? I'm open. 'Cause you could throw me an idea and that gives me another place to go. I go oh, okay, I hear that, I'm going there. You know? So instead of the old, you know, my bag of tricks you know okay well I'm going to throw this trick in here you know, so it's nice sometimes to get a little bit of boost from somebody you know or a harmony. "Oh man you play too much of that" you know. "Here try this seven flat five chord" or whatever it is. You know? They'll shove this in your face. Whole tone scale, something different, anything. So I don't mind that as long as I can hear it and it's a helper. But you know when you play with people a lot you get used to each other, you learn what to do and what not to do.

MR: Did you have sort of an alarming moment the first time you played gigs with a girl singer, a woman singer, to find out that a lot of those tunes that you already knew were like a fourth or fifth away. Was that an issue?

TM: Oh in different keys?

MR: Different keys, yeah.

TM: Yeah sometimes. But most of the time on bass it's not a big problem because of the way the bass is set up. It's just basically playing the same finger patterns but moving your hand to a different area. It's not like you have to play the black keys or you know, whatever they go through – madness with saxophones and trumpet you know. So it's just basically playing the same lick but sliding on the neck to a different place you know. So it's easier for us. Yeah.

MR: Yeah.

TM: But you have to play the right note. I've screwed some singers up.

MR: What was it like, was it this Betty Buckley, was that an ensemble experience?

TM: Say it again?

MR: Was that a like a band? Was that a quartet or was that a larger thing?

TM: Oh there was different, there was a lot of different – when we started with her she ended up getting Kenny Werner to do musical arrangements for her. So he would bring in some friends. We had synthesizer, we had violin, we had Billy Drewes on whatever horns he was playing you know could be flute, whatever, clarinet to alto, tenor you know, and guitar a couple of times they would use, drums, sometimes drums and percussion. Well we played with Jamey Haddad was a great drummer/percussionist you know. Jamey and I played with her and then we did Dave Liebman as well in the beginning, in the early '90s, late '80s. So there was always that – she was big into colors like Dave Liebman and improv. But it was still basically playing for a singer you know. I mean it wasn't like the

band opening up and you know, hitting hard. We were still playing a show for – but it was really beautiful stuff 'cause Kenny had such a great command on harmony you know. It went into duos, man that was a mind-blower because he would just open up like turning on a faucet of the sink and he would throw everything out there you know. And she would be right on it. She would come right back and I mean I'd be lost sometimes, we'd take it so far out. But she nailed it. She was like right in every beat with her – with him you know? It was great. It was a good experience. And we also did pops. She had some of his tunes arranged and orchestrated by Don Sebesky so, you know, top flight guys you know and beautiful with orchestra you know. But then you're not, you know, you've got to put your Scott LaFaro licks in the back. You're playing half notes but you're loving it because it's so beautiful you know. "My Ship" was one of the great arrangements Kenny did. Beautiful.

MR: How do you get up for a studio date over the years. Is playing in the studio sort of a different mindset than being in a live situation?

TM: Oh my God, yeah. I'm still trying to get used to being in the studio you know. I've had experiences playing with real studio guys, this one saxophone player – well a lot of them but I mean George Young, this one guy I played with a lot, that was what he did, he excelled at it. So when he – he did so many sessions. He would take another take on something and he would always improve. I mean he just knew how – he was so defined you know. It's like playing under a microscope you know. So your every note, your every breath, everything is so documented that it's nerve-wracking you know. In live performance you get to let loose and not worry as much you know. So we all want that live recording because we all want that raw – because one of the hardest things to do is to get a great live recording you know? You get a great sound, or, there's always something that messes it up you know. Whatever. It could be feedback, something broke.

MR: Somebody yelling something from the audience.

TM: I prefer playing a club or that's where I can really get going, and then also over like a big stage. I like a small intimate club. That's my favorite hit.

MR: That's why the Delaware Water Gap gig there was right up your alley.

TM: Oh yeah.

MR: Do you have a spot on stage that you usually like to stand? I know some – I've heard bass players saying, "Well I want to be on your hi-hat side" or something like that.

TM: Yeah a lot of guys are that way. I like to be in the middle for sure, between whatever the chordal instrument is and the drums, and I don't have to be on the hi-hat side. When I'm locking in my time, I'm listening to what the right hand or – not everybody is a right handed drummer – but the time. Where the quarter note is coming from if we're playing swing and jazz. You know? I want to know – that's where I get the time from, his hands,

more than that hi-hat two and four. You know. So I'm listening for that. And that lets me know if I'm in sync with his quarter note, if I'm a little behind I'm a little bit – and every drummer's different. You know I play with guys that really are on top of the beat and you've really gotta push. And then you get used to playing with a guy like that, then you're playing with someone that plays a little behind the beat and you're pushing him and you don't want to push him. You know? You want to relax and breathe. You know I played – I noticed that playing with some tenor players and I was pushing them. I must have been playing with Lieb and it was, you know, fast. And I had to step back and say no I'm pushing him. You know? You've got a big space for every beat you know. Galper talked about that too, Hal Galper, when I play with him about the big beat. That was his whole thing, the big beat you know. So you know there's a lot of room in that big beat. So you've got a guy that's playing, I mean you don't want to drag the tempo either but you have to – you've got to leave space for a guy like that. You know? That's the way he plays. You know I don't want to crush him.

MR: I remember hearing Louis Hayes and I think it was Ron Carter on bass at the Iridium. This was quite a few years ago. And Louis Hayes was so on top of the beat that I couldn't understand how the song did not speed up like significantly. How is that possible? Man he just like constant push yet not speeding up I guess.

TM: Yeah well you know some people have set it up as a big circle you know. So you could be a little bit ahead you know, or you could be a little behind. We could be right in the middle. I always kind of felt Paul Chambers and that group of Miles Davis were kind of right on the beat you know. And when you listen to Elvin Jones and Jimmy Garrison I always felt they were just a little behind. They left more room for Elvin's big circular triplety things that he did. And when you listen to Ron Carter and Tony Williams they were flying ahead man, they were definitely on top of the beat you know. And they did get faster at times. You know? Things did get a little faster. But that never bothered me you know. It's the excitement of the music at the time you know. And the things they did, they changed the grooves. And of course we all adored those bands you know so –

MR: Indeed.

TM: Yeah.

MR: Did you ever have what we might call a train wreck? A gig that sticks in your mind as – oh I wish I could do that again or I wish that had never --

TM: Always.

MR: Always?

TM: Oh there's always something that I wish I could have done better you know. And there's times where I felt really good about it. Especially when you listen back, if something's recorded you know, if you listen to it fresh and go oh boy, I'm sorry I did that one, oh

here it comes again. You're so used to yourself you know. Then six months down the road you'll hear it, and you'll hear it in a different light you know, "Oh it's not too bad" you know. But oh I've had train wrecks, that's for sure. Fortunately nothing high meaning – I'm trying to find a word – top shelf gig. You know that hasn't happened to me. Because usually when you're doing those gigs you're very well rehearsed as well. When we go we work on the song form and whatever the tunes are and really work on it. There's always little flubs here and there. You know it's not perfection. In a lot of ways our music isn't perfect that way. Not like classical. You know we're open. And you know if you blow something that might open the door for something else, you never know.

MR: That you wouldn't have played, yeah, if you hadn't sort of mis-stepped.

TM: No, we didn't think of that before, let's go there. You know? Let's do it. You know? That's fun. That's what makes it so much fun, all little things like that you know, and being different. Every time we play it's different, you know, it's never quite the same, even though the head and the chords are the same, you know, the inflection is different.

MR: If I was sitting in that couch with you and you had CDs or LPs and I said, "Put on something that you're really proud of – that your playing was really – what might you pick?

TM: Wow. That's a hard question for me. I have to really – I should have thought about that before. Oh man, I've done a lot of stuff and I would pinpoint probably Dave Liebman in some things. There was a band that we played with he got me on, which was with two saxophones and bass and drums and that was a fun band. I would probably put that on the top of the list in a lot of ways 'cause it was so open and, you know, no chordal instrument. So I'm more open that way. And I felt I did a great job. If I was going to pick something it would probably be something like that you know. I'd have to go through the archives. I don't know. It's a hard question.

MR: There was an interesting, fairly brief video of Dave Liebman talking about free jazz and he said some helpful things about it but he admitted that the average listener a lot of times won't like it.

TM: No.

MR: So I'm thinking if you're a bass player and you're playing, you know, this term "free jazz" is arguable, but it seems to me that you're the person in the group that can decide where to go harmonically if you want to. Is it hard not to go to some key?

TM: Yeah. Well I think when I'm playing free I treat it like I'm playing on a tune a lot of times you know. I listen for tones and key centers and I hear – sometimes it's colors and noise. I don't know how to describe it. White noise it can be. It can go anywhere. You know? But it's everybody doing it together you know, everybody trying to get to a place. The concentration is so hard in free playing, at least in my experience. I used to play a lot

when I was young and we would do all free playing for like an hour or so, or maybe more. And then take a break, come back and play free again, and try different, every kind of color you could think of on your instrument, you know, to utilize. Soft, loud, high, fast, you know whatever. But the thing I found out when I was playing free is I wasn't afraid to try anything you know. Where in chord changes you clam up, you're scared, unless you have like a great list of repertoire and licks you know, that you can run to immediately and get going. Get yourself started. But in the beginning, you know you're not afraid to try things. So then we would finish playing free and then we would play tunes like Bill Evans' trio. And I felt a lot more at ease playing on those tunes because I just spent all this time concentrating you know, and then I'd find out oh, well I didn't do so good on that part, that's something to practice you know. And I'd go home and I'd practice that section of the tune and get better at it you know. And so I don't know if that was really helpful, I don't know if I answered your question.

MR: I think you did. It has to do I believe with your concept of what is a mistake.

TM: Yeah. Absolutely.

MR: Or are there mistakes.

TM: There's no mistake in free. You know we used to always end the thing with the pianos, talking about Lieb, a free ballad. In the encore we'd always do a free ballad. And they loved it.

MR: Who would start it?

TM: You were talking about leading the harmony, I could in that situation.

MR: Who would start it?

TM: Well we would just start – he would just drop the bell on the saxophone and just start. You know? So it's open. You know? It could be solo sax and then the other sax joins and I come in or we all come in at the same time, or we'll count tempo and then we just play free and it was always short and sweet, but it was sometimes beautiful.

MR: I can imagine that if you recorded those things you might actually be able to extract something and write a tune, make it into a –

TM: Oh I think so, sure. Sure. There's definitely bits and pieces you could write from. And he did, he wrote a lot of – Lieb wrote a lot of things like line writing, which I tried to do from him, you know, I would do the same. Atonal or just to use that as an idea so that you can get started on something then improvise off of that melody or whatever you want to call an atonal melody. And then you would have a bookend you know, so you could play that thing where it's just a semblance, out. So you have a beginning and an end you know. But it would be atonal. And that's not for everybody's ears either. You know? My family wouldn't like it.

MR: I think you were involved with Dave in Coltrane tributes?

TM: Yeah.

MR: Coltrane-themed records, recordings.

TM: Yeah he did "Coltrane's Meditation" it was every five years he would do it. And I got to do a few of them. I got to do them in Europe and I got to play double bass with Reggie Workman for instance. The one we recorded was with Cecil McBee. I did it once in the Water Gap with Michael Formanek that both of us played. So there were a few episodes of that he would do you know, and his wife Caris wrote/transcribed the melodies and so we had that form to pull out. I remember when we played with – it was Reggie Workman, and Billy Hart with the other drummer Jamey Haddad. There was two drummers, two bass players. And Sonny Fortune I remember. And the next day we were at breakfast and I'm sitting there and Reggie Workman comes in and I was thrilled to be sitting with him and Sonny Fortune. "Coltrane didn't write that shit out. You know? He didn't write any of that out." He was upset that there was written music. But I took care of that. You know he didn't have to. I just let him go and do what he does you know. And I took care of the mopping up the floor and, you know. So but it was a great experience and in Europe too where it works there. And it works in New York too, not everywhere but.

MR: Rubbing elbows with those gentlemen from the earlier era is so enriching.

TM: Yeah. Oh it is. You get on a bus and some of these greats come and they start talking stories and I mean it's just – you realize they're human and it's so great to, you know, experience what they experienced you know. But you know when you think about the older black musicians with the racial thing they had to go through, I don't have a clue. What that was, I'll never know what that is. You know but they never – I mean my experience is I didn't feel ever that racial thing with them. They always made me feel welcome into the music you know. And Clark Terry – he was a great storyteller. We were on the bus once you know and Lieb was a really good – he'd be a good emcee on a talk show, because he would ask the questions to get him going. And it was really fun on that bus ride to the venue to be with Clark Terry and hear his stories, Miles' drug addiction or whatever. It was great to be – what a great spirit man. Wow.

MR: I was able to have some of that spirit next to me in this project I do, so I know what you're talking about.

TM: Yeah. They lived a special life you know. And we try to make 'em proud, hopefully.

MR: What gigs – your current calendar, what's it look like these days?

TM: Well nothing major. I do these little gigs around me here, like little restaurants, breweries, you know, community concerts. I do church gigs with this – not far from me there's a reverend, he's originally from New York State, Bill Carter. He has a band and he connects his sermon – he's a Presbyterian minister – spirituality with jazz. And he's very

into it. And he writes some beautiful stuff. So we record records and we're going to Georgia at the end of September. And that's about it. I mean Deer Head, a festival that they just had in Scranton, the Water Gap Festival is coming up so there'll be a lot of musicians playing at that. So it's small community concerts, clubs, restaurant, Deer Head Inn, you know, Lafayette Bar in Easton, you know I'll be there Friday so you know, I've been busy. It's been a decent summer and I'm happy whenever I get a gig. You know? They're not always pristine, great gigs. People talk and we've got to fight through that but we're playing together and it feels good that we're playing you know. And we have good moments playing you know? It's worth it.

MR: So when folks eventually watch this video on our Fillius Jazz YouTube channel I'm going to suggest that they Google you and a fellow named Joe Wagner, guitar player?

TM: Hmm. Yeah.

MR: And you were playing the tune "Afro Blue."

TM: Yeah?

MR: Just the two of you.

TM: Yeah.

MR: It was way hip.

TM: Oh good. I don't remember it that much but yeah.

MR: You both were playing your instruments like they were drums for a while.

TM: Oh, good. I like that, I like opening up that way.

MR: Yeah. And then it was just very spontaneous and creative and every once in a while you getting back to that melody thing, you'd hop up to the melody and play [scats]. And it made for, like I don't know if there's markers in music I think that help. If your mind is wandering all of a sudden someone plays something and you go ut – yeah. It sort of brings you back in.

TM: We do that often. You know? Especially for drum solo when everything drops out and it's just him. I mean I'm not talking about trading eights, I'm talking about whole song forms you know. So but we'll drop in whatever little rhythmic entity there is to bring into the bridge or something, or it might be something at the end of the tune, and then we'll just wait for that and we'll hit it every time, just so that – I think it helps the audience too, to bring them into – we're listening, we're not chewing gum and running to the bar. I've had that happen to me too during bass solo, you know, where the horn players run to the bar and have a taste. And I'm done with my solo and there's no one there to bring me out of it. That used to get me a little mad.

MR: I would think so.

TM: Come on, man, listen. Dave Liebman, I'll listen to every note. Phil Woods listened to every note. I mean when you get that level player there wasn't one breath of music that

they missed. They were in there. And then the next day in the bus you know, talking about remembering what was good and what wasn't good. They just were constantly – I mean Lieb was that way definitely, constantly on it. Never gave it up. Sometimes, uh oh, what's he going to say now. "Letter A on -- " Mostly the chord player. Mostly the chord players got it, I didn't get much, I was lucky you know, I did my job. You know he wanted me to break things up. He didn't want me to stay constant, and he wanted the drummer to be very open to any kind of groove change or just something to make the music exciting, and then colors. He was big into colors so whatever effects a guitar or piano would use or chords to change colors you know, that was what the band was based on you know.

MR: There you go.

TM: So it was a great experience. Yeah. Lucky to have been doing that for 30 odd years.

MR: 30 odd years, so last question, sort of finish the sentence. Making a living as a professional musician has been –

TM: Ooh. Has been beautiful, I feel very lucky to have done what I did and I raised three kids and I didn't have to go get that proverbial day job you know. I did some teaching but I never did it as heavy as other friends of mine did it, and for me it was always word of mouth you know, I'm not a big computer self-promoter. You know? I'm not into that. I'm old fashioned that way I guess. I still like pen and paper and I'm not – the old everything on the computer and the iPhone escapes me. I'm not there. So I'm going to miss out on AI I guess. I don't know if I'm going to be part of that whole scene. But I feel very lucky. I guess that was a run-on sentence.

MR: No, that was a fine answer because you could have gone the other way, you can been like it's incredibly hard and don't do it unless you –

TM: Oh no. I think everybody that loves to play should play you know. Phil Woods would say you know, "Put a saxophone in a kid's hand instead of a gun" you know? And it's the truth. Let him get his emotions out that way. I remember telling kids when you're mad – you're mad at your mother for whatever man, you go in the room and practice for an hour and take your aggression out on your instrument. And you'll find out an hour later or so, you'll feel better. It's like a way – you know you can find out how you can use that on the bandstand, that anger. You know? Or the joy. Whatever it is.

MR: Cool. Well that's a great way to wrap up our conversation. I realy enjoyed chatting with you, Tony.

TM: Oh Monk, it was a pleasure. The same. And I hope you could see more than just my bouncing ball here. I wasn't sure of the video.

MR: All right. I'll just pause here and we'll say our good-byes.

TM: Okay.

MR: Thank you.

TM: Thank you, Monk.